

Start with one workflow

From using AI to running on it: find where it helps, test it in 30 days, make it stick.



8 STEPS

| 7 WORKSHEETS

| A 30-DAY PLAN

Every business will use AI. Very few will run on it.

We've spoken with 50+ companies about AI. Most had already tried it: a subscription, an app, a training day. Weeks later, the work still ran the old way. The same reasons keep coming up:

Tool first. The right first question is where you're losing time, money or customers.

Everything at once. Ten ideas, no owner, nothing finished.

Scattered data. Prices in one file, customers in chats, answers in someone's head.

AI outside the work. People copy from a chat window into WhatsApp, then give up.

The fix: one workflow, done properly, in three phases.

Your role as the founder. Pick the workflow, name its owner, and make the call on review day. Your team does the rest. And "build" doesn't mean code: your first pilot runs on WhatsApp, a spreadsheet and an AI assistant like ChatGPT, Gemini or Claude.

THE 8 STEPS

IDENTIFY

- 1 Find the leak** Pick your costliest workflow
- 2 Map the work** See how it really runs
- 3 Sort every step** Fix, automate, AI or human
- 4 Check what AI can't fix** Data layer, owner, team, risk

BUILD

- 5 Design the new workflow** System, AI and person lanes
- 6 Run a small pilot** Two weeks of real work

HANDOVER

- 7 Make it stick** Train, check in, fix weekly
- 8 Scale, fix or stop** Decide with numbers

Find the leak

Pick the workflow that costs you the most, not the most exciting.

A workflow is work that repeats in the same steps, like:

enquiry → reply → quote → follow-up.

Leaks hide where work waits on one person.

WORKSHEET · SCORE YOUR CANDIDATES (1 = LOW, 5 = HIGH)

WORKFLOW	OFTEN	HURTS	PREDICTABLE	MEASURABLE	TOTAL

Put a number on it.

Weekly hours × 52 × what an hour costs you = what this leak costs a year: _____

EXAMPLE BUSINESS (ILLUSTRATIVE)

One business runs through every step: 40 enquiries a week arrive on two WhatsApp numbers, calls, Instagram. Three salespeople handle them.

The founder said: **"We get enough enquiries. We don't close enough, and I can't see where they slip."**

Enquiry → quote → follow-up scores **19 out of 20 here.**

At about 55 minutes each, that's **37 hours a week.**

Elyst AI rule #1. Choose the boring workflow that touches money over the one that makes a good demo.

Map how the work really happens

You know how it should work. Your team knows how it actually works.

Walk through the last three real examples with the person who does the work. For every step, note who, where (app, sheet, chat or paper) and how long. Tag the trouble: **WAIT**, **RETYPE**, **ERROR** or **JUDGMENT** (a person must decide). Your "where" column is the first sketch of your data layer.

WORKSHEET · TODAY'S MAP

#	STEP	WHO	WHERE	TIME	TROUBLE	SORT
1						
2						
3						
4						
5						

EXAMPLE MAP (ILLUSTRATIVE)

STEP	WHERE	TIME	TROUBLE
Enquiry arrives	Two WhatsApp numbers, calls, Instagram, email	–	WAIT: some missed
Ask what they need	WhatsApp, phone	10 min	WAIT
Check price and stock	Excel, a call to the store	10 min	RETYPE, WAIT
Prepare the quote	Word template	20 min	RETYPE, ERROR
Approve the discount	Manager, on WhatsApp	5 min	WAIT: hours
Send the quote	WhatsApp, email	5 min	–
Follow up	Memory	5 min	Often missed

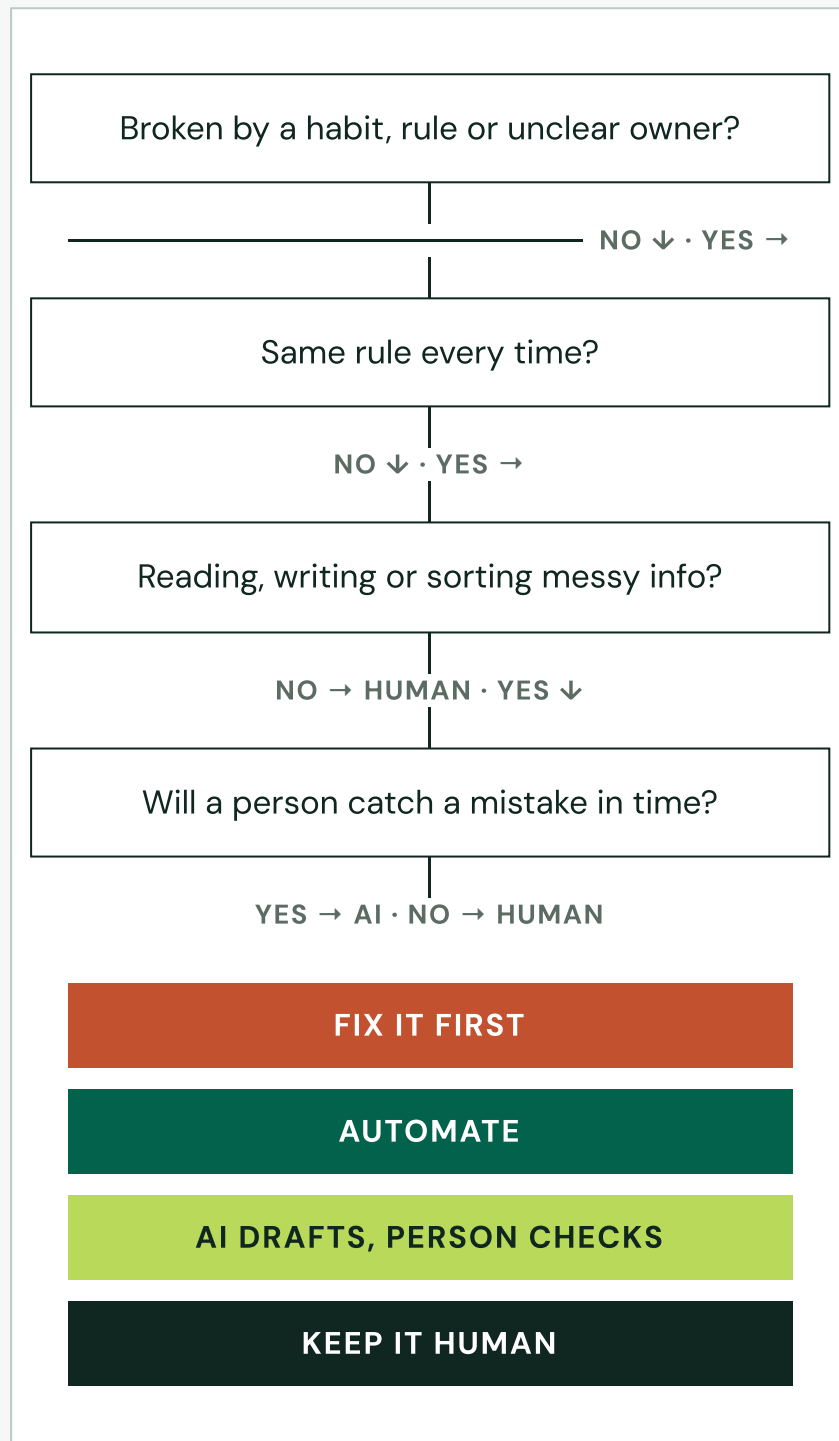
The first reply takes about 2 hours, and only 4 in 10 quotes get a follow-up. The waiting costs more than the typing, and waiting isn't a technology problem.

Elyst AI rule #2. Map the busy works that consumes the day, not what looks fancy.

Sort every step: Fix, Automate, AI or Human

Most steps don't need AI. They need something simpler.

Run each step on your map through these four questions, and write the answer in the Sort column.



EXAMPLE BUSINESS (ILLUSTRATIVE)

STEP	SORT	WHAT CHANGES
Enquiry arrives	FIX AUTO	One WhatsApp number, one owner, a tracker row per enquiry
Ask what they need	AI	AI drafts; a salesperson checks and sends
Check price and stock	FIX	One price sheet, updated daily
Prepare the quote	AUTO AI	The template does the maths; AI fills in the details
Approve the discount	FIX	Up to 5% needs no approval
Send the quote	HUMAN	A person sends every quote
Follow up	AUTO AI	The tracker flags day 2 and day 5; AI drafts the message

Only three of the seven steps need AI.

Elyst AI rule #3. Sometimes the best AI project has no AI in it.

Check what AI can't fix

AI can draft, sort and summarise.
It can't organise your data, own the work, or win over your team.

Start with your data layer.

It's the one place a workflow's information lives: the records it creates (every enquiry, quote and follow-up) and the knowledge it runs on (prices, stock, standard answers).
AI is only as good as the data it can reach.

WORKSHEET · FIVE CHECKS

Green is fine for a pilot. Red is not.

CHECK	GREEN	RED	YOURS
Data layer	Records and knowledge in one place, current	Scattered across chats, files and heads	☐
Owner	One named person, ideally not you	"Everyone", so no one	☐
No second system	Works inside tools your team already uses	Copying between screens all day	☐
Checker	Checking AI's work is faster than doing it	Nobody has time to check	☐
Cheap mistakes	A person sees AI's work before a customer does	A wrong answer can reach a customer	☐

Before pasting customer details into any AI tool, check its data settings and share only what the task needs.

EXAMPLE BUSINESS (ILLUSTRATIVE)

Their data layer: an enquiry tracker, the price sheet, and an answer bank of the 20 questions customers ask most. Two ambers: the answer bank had to be written first, and AI drafts in a separate chat window during the pilot. Fine for two weeks.

Elyst AI rule #4. If nobody can say who checks the AI's work, you're not ready to switch it on.

Design the new workflow

Put every step in one lane. All three work from the same data layer, so nothing gets retyped.
Unusual cases always go to a person, and if AI fails, the old way still works.

EXAMPLE (ILLUSTRATIVE)

SYSTEM	Logs every enquiry in the tracker and flags follow-ups due on day 2 and day 5
AI	Drafts replies, quote details and follow-ups
PERSON	Checks and sends every message, sets prices, handles complaints and custom orders
DATA	Enquiry tracker · Price sheet · Answer bank

WORKSHEET · YOUR LANES

SYSTEM	
AI	
PERSON	
DATA	

Brief your AI like a new hire. Save it as a custom GPT, Claude Project, Gemini Gem or a note.

Role: You are the sales assistant for [business]. We sell [what] to [who].
Task: Draft a reply to the message below. Never send anything.
Use only: our price sheet and answer bank.
Never: invent prices, stock or delivery dates.
Tone: short and friendly, in the customer's language.
If unsure: start with "CHECK:" and ask [name].

Elyst AI rule #5. The new workflow lives where your team already works. One more app to open, and they will quietly stop.

Run a small pilot

Two weeks. Real work. Two or three people. Numbers before and after.

- 1
- Measure the "before". One normal week, the old way.
Without it, you will only know how AI felt.
- 2
- Pick two or three users, including one sceptic. They find the real problems fastest.
- 3
- Set targets the workflow controls: speed, follow-ups, errors, hours. Not sales.
- 4
- Write the stop rule now, while you're still objective.

Let the data layer do the counting. If every enquiry has a timestamped row, reply times count themselves. Run the "automatic" parts by hand at first, and automate once it works.

WORKSHEET · PILOT SCORECARD

MEASURE	BEFORE	TARGET	WEEK 1	WEEK 2
AI drafts used with light edits				
Work done the new way				

Stop rule: If _____ by _____, we stop and rethink.

Elyst AI rule #6. Count the checking time. If fixing an AI draft takes longer than writing it, AI made that step slower.

Make it stick

A tool your team doesn't use is just a monthly bill.

Pilots rarely get cancelled. They fade, because the old way is familiar and nobody asks what's in the way.

WORKSHEET · HANDOVER CHECKLIST

- ☐ Trained on our own real work, not generic demos
- ☐ Everyone has the kit: AI brief, answer bank, three great examples
- ☐ Go-to person on the team, not you: _____
- ☐ 15-minute check-in every week, fixing one thing: _____
- ☐ Old way closed, so there's only one way to do it: _____
- ☐ Team told why: AI takes the repetitive work, they keep the judgment

EXAMPLE BUSINESS (ILLUSTRATIVE)

Week 1: replies sounded stiff, so they added three of their best real replies as examples.

Week 2: a large order got a standard reply, so big orders now go straight to the sales lead.

Elyst AI rule #7. A workshop is a start, not a solution. People learn AI on their own work.

Scale it, fix it, or stop it

Put the numbers next to the "before" and make one call.

WORKSHEET · THE DECISION

	SCALE	FIX	STOP
When	Targets met, people use it, mistakes are rare	Some targets met, and you can name what's wrong	Poor quality, no usage, or checking costs more than it saves
Then	Roll it out, connect the tools properly, pick the next workflow	Change one or two things and run two more weeks	Stop, and write down what you learned
Your call	☐	☐	☐

EXAMPLE BUSINESS AFTER TWO WEEKS (ILLUSTRATIVE)

Their call: scale replies and follow-ups, and hand custom quotes back to a person. That's why hands-on time missed its target.

Elyst AI rule #8. Stopping a pilot isn't failure. Scaling one nobody uses is.

BEFORE / TARGET / AFTER

MEASURE	BEFORE	TARGET	AFTER
First reply	About 3 hours	Under 30 min	25 min
Hands-on time / enquiry	55 min	Under 30 min	35 min
Quotes followed up	4 in 10	9 in 10	9 in 10
AI drafts, light edits	–	7 in 10	8/10 replies, 2/10 quotes

Then go again. Every workflow you fix adds to your data layer, so the next one starts faster. That's how a business ends up running on AI.

Your next 30 days

Print it. Fill it in. Put it where you'll see it.

My workflow

What it costs today (hours a week)

Owner

Pilot starts

Review day

Every week this waits, it costs you the hours you wrote above.

THE 30-DAY PLAN, RECAPPED

Week 1. Score and pick your workflow. Map it with the person who does it. Measure a normal week.

Week 2. Sort every step and make the no-tech fixes. Set up your data layer. Draw the lanes and write the AI brief.

Weeks 3 and 4. Pilot with two or three people. Check in weekly and fix one thing.

Day 30. Scale, fix or stop. Then pick the next workflow.

On the call, we don't pitch, quote or demo anything. We ask how your work runs today. If something's worth doing, we come back within five business days with a map: what we found, ranked by what it costs you, and what we'd do first. If not, we'll say so.

Want a second pair of eyes?

You can do all of this yourself. If you'd rather not, this is our work. We help businesses run on AI, not just use it:

Identify. We find where AI really helps, and where it doesn't.

Build. We design the workflow around how your team already works.

Handover. We train your team, then step back. You own it, not us.

[Book a 30-minute call](#)